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SmartNote

Summary

The meeting covered a research project with 412 Food Rescue to design an algorithm for fairer donation allocation and walked the participant through a 45-scenario decision exercise. The discussion then explored how the participant actually reasons about allocation, what “fairness” means to them, feedback on the survey, and details about their pantry’s operations and partnerships.

Key takeaway

Research Goal: Fair Donation Allocation Algorithm

- The team is developing a computer algorithm with 412 Food Rescue to allocate donations more fairly and efficiently amid rising demand and limited staff capacity.
- The facilitator explained that 412 Food Rescue is facing demand beyond staff capacity and is seeking algorithmic support for donation allocation, with a focus on fairness and equity.

Scenario Exercise and Decision Factors

- The participant completed 45 scenarios, consistently using specific indicators (income, poverty, food access, organization size, donation history, and travel time) to choose between two potential recipient organizations.
- The facilitator described each scenario as a choice between two recipients with attributes such as donation type (common vs. high-demand items), organization size, client income/poverty, food access, travel time, and past donations.
- The participant repeatedly stated choosing A or B based on combinations of income level, poverty rate, organization size, level of food access, donation mix, donation frequency, and occasionally travel time.

Fairness Criteria and Emotional Response

- The participant experiences guilt in making allocation decisions but defines fairness as equal treatment across communities and non-discrimination across demographic groups.
- They reported feeling guilty when choosing between similar cases, worrying that small differences (like organization size) might unfairly deprive another area that also needs food.
- They described fair allocation as ensuring communities in places like Oakland and Duquesne receive comparable treatment, without discrimination by age, gender, sex, sexual orientation, or other affiliations, and with efforts to direct people to locations where food is available if allocations differ.

Feedback on Survey Design and Missing Factors

- The participant found the survey clear, visually effective, and thought-provoking, and did not identify major missing factors beyond those already included.
- They praised the visual representation and said it helped them think through decisions, noting that sometimes they still had to make essentially arbitrary choices when factors were very similar.
- When asked about additional factors, they affirmed that the key ones—especially fresh produce vs. bread, drive distance for volunteers, and income level—were appropriately captured.

Pantry Access Policy and Client Qualification

- Their pantry serves all clients with minimal barriers, using self-declared income and no ID requirements to avoid excluding anyone.
- They explained that clients provide basic demographic data for reporting and sign a self-declaration that their income is below a set threshold, with no ID or documentation required, which they believe prevents access barriers.

Scale of Operations and Client Health Needs

- The pantry operates at large scale with a strong emphasis on fresh produce to address high rates of diabetes and diet-related health issues among clients.
- They serve about 670 families (around 2,800 individuals) per month and distribute roughly 11,000 pounds of food per week, focusing on fresh produce and client education on how to use it.
- They noted that around three-quarters of their clients have diabetes or are at high risk, linking this to the high sodium content of canned goods common at other pantries.

Partnerships and Resource Differences Between Large and Small Pantries

- The pantry’s long-term presence in Oakland has enabled broad partnerships and donation streams that many smaller organizations lack, though networks are emerging to support smaller pantries.
- They described partnerships with UPMC, local universities, and large employers like Highmark, along with food drives and move-out donations, as key sources of canned goods and other items.
- They contrasted this with smaller organizations that are not yet “stakeholders,” noting that the Greater Pittsburgh Community Food Bank is pairing larger and smaller pantries and delivering free fresh produce to help smaller sites build momentum and access.

Chapters

Introduction to the Research and Study Goals
The facilitator explains the research project's purpose, focusing on addressing increased demand faced by 412 Food Rescue and developing an algorithm for equitable donation distribution. The speaker outlines that the study aims to define fairness in donation allocation through stakeholder interviews and input.
0s

Overview of the Donation Scenarios Exercise
The facilitator describes the structure of the exercise, where participants act as donation managers. They are asked to choose between recipients in 45 donation scenarios. The variables influencing decisions include donation types, recipient size, food access level, income, poverty rate, travel time, and donation history.
44s

Participant Begins Scenario Decision-Making
The participant starts making decisions within the scenarios, explaining rationales such as prioritizing lower income levels, higher poverty rates, and new organizations. The facilitator provides clarifications when needed and ensures understanding of the selection process.
4m 46s

Decision Reasoning and Scenario Progression
The participant continues choosing between recipients, justifying selections based on criteria like organizational size, level of food access, income level, past donations, and poverty rate. The facilitator occasionally assists with technical issues and scenario explanations.
5m 44s

Post-Survey Reflection on Fairness and Decision Process
After completing the scenarios, the facilitator asks reflective questions about the participant’s thought process. The participant shares feelings of guilt when deciding between similar cases and believes fairness means equal treatment across diverse communities, free from discrimination.
19m 20s

Feedback on the Survey and Missing Factors
The participant provides feedback, stating that the visual design helps decision-making and that the survey felt clear and effective. They mention that factors like travel distance and income levels are important considerations and affirm that freshness and type of donations are key decision drivers.
22m 21s

Food Pantry Operations and Accessibility
The conversation shifts to operations at the participant’s food pantry. They describe serving about 670 families per month and emphasize inclusivity, self-declaration for income verification, and avoiding ID requirements. They highlight education on fresh produce and its health benefits for clients.
22m 54s

Discussion on Differences Between Large and Small Recipients
The facilitator observes that the participant often favors larger recipient organizations. The participant explains that larger pantries like theirs have more established partnerships with groups such as UPMC and universities, while smaller ones rely on support from programs like the Greater Pittsburgh Community Food Bank to grow.
24m 29s

Closing Remarks and Tour Invitation
The facilitator requests to take a photo and tour of the pantry, and the participant agrees, offering to show the waiting area. The conversation concludes amicably with gratitude and cooperation.
26m 32s

Transcript

SPEAKER 1
So what we'll be doing today so kind of the context of why we're doing this research is because for one two food rescue has seen a increase in demand beyond their staff capacity, and they're seeking more efficient ways to allocate donation donations. Okay. So we are partnering with them to build a computer algorithm to assist the donation process. One of our goal is to keep donation fair and equitable. As part of our research, we are talking to stakeholders like yourselves to learn what you think is a fair allocation because there's no one answer when it comes to a fair algorithm.

SPEAKER 2
Right.

SPEAKER 1
To learn when you think it's fair, we'll ask you to pick the winning recipient of a series of 45 donation scenarios. This will take a longer time in the beginning, but it will go faster once you get used to flow of it. Okay. We have a booklet of kind of the scenario. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
So you can go up here together. Okay. So, basically, you are role playing the manager of phones from rescue. Okay. So you're in the situation where you're deciding between two recipients.

SPEAKER 1
Sure. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
Okay. So so the first scenario it says an example would be, big grocery notices an abundance of fresh produce that could go bad if you need. So from there, like, what do I just say where I think the food should go?

SPEAKER 1
Or So we have, like, a the actual scenarios will

SPEAKER 2
look Sure.

SPEAKER 1
Like this. Okay. Awesome. Yeah. So so, basically, all the sort of recipients will have different factors k.

SPEAKER 1
That you can use to decide which one you wanna give this donation to. Okay. First of all, here is the incoming donation Okay. Which breaks down into common and less common donations. Common donations which could be produce or bread Right.

SPEAKER 1
Which takes up about 70% of the total donation Okay. From food, apartment. Right. Yeah. And the less common of high demand ones being like non food or dairy products.

SPEAKER 1
Oh. The recipient org size Mhmm. Is how how many clients they serve Right. On a monthly basis. Level of food access is how far close the client is from the nearest grocery store.

SPEAKER 2
Okay.

SPEAKER 1
And so if they're extremely low or low, they are in a food desert.

SPEAKER 2
Oh, yes. That's what I'm just trying to, like, consider just because Allegheny County is a desert.

SPEAKER 1
I see.

SPEAKER 2
Classified. Yeah. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Income level and income and poverty rate is Right. The level of the area that the client resides in, not where the recipient is.

SPEAKER 2
Oh, okay. Okay. That makes sense. Mhmm. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Travel time is how long it takes for the volunteer to take the donation from the donor to the recipient. Okay. Last donation is when they receive the last. And total donation received is how much donation they received from four one two in the last three months.

SPEAKER 2
Okay.

SPEAKER 1
And it breaks down into common donations, which is a darker blue Right. And the less common, which is the lighter blue. Okay. And so you'll go through 45 of these randomly generated

SPEAKER 2
Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Recipients. Okay. And after you make your decisions about A or B, it will be helpful for you to tell us, like, kind of briefly why you chose A or B.

SPEAKER 2
Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Or if it was kind of just a decision, it's also okay to say that.
Okay. Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
Sounds good. So

SPEAKER 1
this looking at first question. And then you can decide here. Okay. But was there anything else unclear?

SPEAKER 2
No. No. Everything was very clear. Very good job. Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
Okay. So then, I just choose which one? And I let you know which one? Mhmm. Okay.

SPEAKER 2
So, I'm choosing b.

SPEAKER 1
B? Yes.

SPEAKER 2
I chose this just based on the income level of clients that they're receiving, the total donations that they've received in the past, and then the poverty rate was the deciding factor as well.

SPEAKER 1
Okay. You can click this And then load the infection.

SPEAKER 2
Okay. Cool. I'm gonna choose A for one just because it would be the first time that they're donating, so I think it'd be a really good chance for them to get started. Mhmm. And then the income levels for their clients, so it's a good starting factor for them to begin that relationship.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. I'm choosing a. And let me crush. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Also, there's a glitch where, like, sometimes it doesn't change. So let me know if

SPEAKER 2
If it doesn't change. Okay. I'm gonna go with B for this one just because they are closer, they have gotten from foreign to in the past, and they get common demand donations. Kind of the same thing again for this one. I'm choosing b Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
Just based on poverty rate and then the donations that they've received, and then they're pretty frequent as a donor. I'm choosing B for this one just because they tend to get common food donations, and they're serving a high population with a lower income rate and poverty and a lower poverty well, high poverty. Sorry. This one, I'm choosing b just based on income level, the type of donations that they've received, and then the the recipient organization size as well. I'm choosing a based on organization size, donation, and then the donation fee type.

SPEAKER 2
I'm gonna choose b for this one based on her organization size, income, and donation received just because we never had that before. I'm choosing a for this one based on level of food access and donations received since they've never done that before. I'll choose a for this one based on donations received. Low level food access, and

SPEAKER 1
then yeah. Those two.

SPEAKER 2
Choosing a based on income level. Choosing a based on level of food access and

SPEAKER 1
yeah. Just level of food access.

SPEAKER 2
I'll choose a for this one just based on organization size. I'm gonna choose a for this one just based on the donations received and the yeah. Donations received.

SPEAKER 1
By the donation received, is the, like

SPEAKER 2
They had just more of a mix, I thought, of the high demand items and other items. So it's an organization that I think would be not dependable, but I think that would be able to use it more frequently. I would, for this one, choose b just to maybe get them into a trend of starting to accept food donations just because they are so frequent that it would make sense to see if they could, take the donation, and then they have a very large organization size as well. I'm gonna choose a for this one based on recipient organization size and the level of food access. I'm gonna choose a for this one based on, level of food access, income level,

SPEAKER 1
and then, do

SPEAKER 2
this too. Choose b on this one based on income level and last donation received. I'm choosing a based on level of food access and the poverty rate. I'm choosing b based on the amount of donations that they've received. I guess travel time would be a good one.

SPEAKER 2
She's not one of you guys do this. This is difficult to choose from. I'm gonna do a based on recipient organization size. B, based on poverty rate. B based on organization size and level of food access.

SPEAKER 2
Do b based off organization size and level of income.

SPEAKER 1
Did not change.

SPEAKER 2
It did not.

SPEAKER 1
Alright.

SPEAKER 2
I'm gonna do b based on income level one. Okay. B based on income level and level of food access. I'll do 11 I mean, I'll be based on the the donations that they've received and then how frequently they're beginning. I'll be based on income level.

SPEAKER 2
B based on poverty rate and level of food access. Honestly am just choosing b just because they've had lesser donations, there might be a frequency for them to accept the common food donation rather than the

SPEAKER 1
less common one. That's my reason. Mhmm. K.

SPEAKER 2
B, just based on level of food access. A, based on organization size and level of food access. B based on level of root access. B, based on donations received, the type of donations, and the level of food access. A, based on the amount of donations they've received, level of food access.

SPEAKER 2
I'm gonna say a for this one just because it's a good starting point. They have extremely low food access, and they never receive a donation. I'll choose a based on the donations B based on organization ties and then just your donations received. B based on recommendation size and level of food access. B based on income level and lost donation.

SPEAKER 2
Be based on food access and the donation. So that's a pretty nice donation. It'd be based on food access and total donations received. B, a, based on poverty rate and income level. A, based on access and organization size.

SPEAKER 2
A, based on poverty rate in organization size. I chose beaches because. A, based on donations received and level of food access.

SPEAKER 1
I think this is, like, probably the last one.

SPEAKER 2
Okay. B, based on organization size. Yeah.

SPEAKER 1
Good question. So about the survey that you just did.

SPEAKER 2
Sure.

SPEAKER 1
Is this something that you think about?

SPEAKER 2
Did I think about?

SPEAKER 1
Yeah. Like, have you ever thought about, like, how for one two might make decisions?

SPEAKER 2
I I do. I mean, a part of me thinks we have a connection just because the prior food pantry coordinator actually works at four one two Rescue. Yeah. So we have not a pool, but I guess that's helpful. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
Being one of the largest food pantries in the area, it's always difficult for me to understand how they, you know, distribute the items. Mhmm. But I know that we're one of the largest in regards to, like, fresh produce, so I always I kept that in mind a little bit too just thinking about how they were going to donate. Because sometimes you do have to act like a salesperson in order to give out the fresh produce to our clients.

SPEAKER 1
Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
So it's more or less thinking about, you know, what areas are actually teaching their clients how to prepare fresh produce. Mhmm. You know, thinking about the storage for food placement as well. So I think that comes into play when I was thinking about just that kind of situation. In

SPEAKER 1
general, how did you feel about the process of making decisions?

SPEAKER 2
I felt guilty. Because I felt that if you gave to one especially like when there was cases where there were very similar circumstances, I felt like I was taking away from an area that maybe needed it, but just based on, you know, a small change of maybe organization size, you would see that that food would be able to get, you know, distributed quicker rather than an organization that didn't have that many persons. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
In your opinion, what does a fair allocation

SPEAKER 2
To me, I think it's just looking at the demographics of an area, ensuring that persons that are living, you know, within Oakland are getting the same treatment persons living in Duquesne are getting. That there's not any discrimination based on age, gender, sex, sexual orientation, or any other affiliations that a person might have. So it's essentially stating that a community in Oakland is getting the same treatment that a community in Duquesne is getting. Or for some reason, if they're not getting that, that that there would be discussion on, you know, pushing to go to a certain pantry or pushing to go to a certain area so that those foods or items could be obtained.

SPEAKER 1
Do you have any suggestions on the survey itself, or can you think of other ways of doing this?

SPEAKER 2
No. Because I think I think the visual representation that you guys have Mhmm. Is very you know, that's visual I'm just a visual person. So for me, seeing that. And then I think it just makes you think a little bit.

SPEAKER 2
And sometimes you just chose because you didn't know what else to choose. So no. I think it's very well.

SPEAKER 1
Was there anything else unclear today? Or maybe as a recipient, is there factors that we're missing?

SPEAKER 2
No. I think what you did was great because for the majority, is, you know, fresh produce that you are getting as that or bread. So that's the deciding factor. Mhmm. There are times where you do have to think about the drive that a person has for donations.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. And then more or less, I think the income level is really important as well. But, no, I think Mhmm. Think you touched on a

SPEAKER 1
lot of the areas. For the CHS for pension, do you have to qualify by, like, income, or is it just all served?

SPEAKER 2
Nope. All are served. Basically this is nice to sit here. So for us Mhmm. We just ask simple demographic information for our own database because we do have to report that at the end of the month.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. And then this is just a self declaration form that you make under the certain amount. So this person having three people in the family clarified that self declares that they make less than $30,000 a year gross or less than $2,500 a month. And that's all we ask of them. No IDs are necessary.

SPEAKER 2
Nothing. We just don't want to ever prohibit or limit somebody based on items that they cannot receive.

SPEAKER 1
I see. And you just still have a trust system?

SPEAKER 2
Yeah. Yeah. Essentially. And that way, we've been able to see our numbers drastically increase unlike other food pantries. So we're serving approximately, like, 670 families a month, which is roughly 2,800 persons.

SPEAKER 2
So, yeah, we go through roughly 11,000 pounds of food a a week just on Wow. Yeah, distributing. And we're known for fresh produce too, and I think the biggest thing is that customer education and food education piece that we really strive on just because half the time, persons don't even know what to do with what they're receiving. So they don't even get it. But, yeah, the fresh produce that eliminates a lot of health factors that we've seen.

SPEAKER 1
Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
So almost seventy five percent of all persons coming to our pantry have diabetes or are prone for diabetes. That's all, like, the salt and sodium that you're getting in canned good items at other pantries. Mhmm. So working with four one two has been awesome just to really push that fresh produce aspect that we have even further.

SPEAKER 1
It seemed like you like, when the organization like, if everything else was similar, you decided to go with, like, the higher serving Right. Recipient. Right. One interesting thing that I saw was, larger organizations have a lot of sources of donations. Right.

SPEAKER 1
Which is that true for Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
Very much so.

SPEAKER 1
And I was just curious, like, if our smaller recipients, do they not have many sources, or is it the same usually?

SPEAKER 2
So it's it's a little bit different for us. It's just that we have so many, like, we've been established in Oakland for so long Mhmm. That we've been been able to form a lot of partnerships with UPMC, all the different universities that are in the area. So we have canned good drives that people do to us, or persons that are moving out always donate or, you know, we have larger organizations like Highmark and everyone else. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
So they've been able to help that way. I just think what's not I I guess what what's different with the smaller organizations is they're not a stakeholder yet, so that way they're not doing that. But what's really nice is that the Greater Pittsburgh Community Food Bank partners larger organizations with smaller organizations to give them the momentum to really get going. But it's I think it's a time right now where, you know, food is, you know, sexy and it's starting to be able to sell. So Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
You really have to jump on board with that right now just to teach persons that kind of thing. I know the food bank Mhmm. Is really pushing and giving incentives for fresh produce right now. So they're delivering fresh produce for free to some smaller pantries that don't have that access just to push that. So I think with us having, you know, the person that used to be here at 412, we have persons that are they used to be here that are at the food bank.

SPEAKER 2
I think we're just got really lucky in our establishment Mhmm. Unlike other pantries.

SPEAKER 1
Actually, can I get a photo of you just, like Sure? Electricity in the service?

SPEAKER 2
Sure. No problem. Absolutely.

SPEAKER 1
Thank you.

SPEAKER 2
No problem.

SPEAKER 1
Can I get a tour of the pension

SPEAKER 2
just Absolutely? Yeah. Take your pictures.

SPEAKER 1
Want to

SPEAKER 2
take look. So this is the waiting area. Mhmm.

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